MENNA CAPELIN BISHOP

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Last updated: October 2026

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics — Sep 2023 – Sep 2027 (expected)
University of Warwick — *Coventry, UK*
Primary field: Development Economics
Secondary fields: Labour Economics, Environmental Economics

MRes in Economics (Distinction) — Sep 2021 – Sep 2023
University of Warwick — *Coventry, UK*

BSc Social Policy and Economics (First Class) — Sep 2016 – Sep 2019
London School of Economics and Political Science — *London, UK*

WORKING PAPERS

"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns" **(Job Market Paper)**.

"Blossoming Towns", with Niclas Moneke and Céline Zipfel.

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Jobs to End Poverty: Evidence from Bangladesh", with Oriana Bandiera, Robin Burgess, Stefano Caria, Munshi Sulaiman and Jack Thiemel (working paper in preparation).

PUBLICATIONS

Fetzer, T., Gazzè, L. and Bishop, M. C. (2024). "Distributional and Climate Implications of Policy Responses to Energy Price Shocks". *Economic Policy*, 39(120), 711–756.

Bishop, M. C., Burgess, R. and Zipfel, C. (2023). "Technology and Development". In Madon, T., Gadgil, A. J., Anderson, R., Casaburi, L., Lee, K., Rezaee, A. (eds), *Introduction to Development Engineering*. Springer, Cham.

CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns"

Econometric Society European Winter Meeting* 2026
Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC), Cornell University* 2026
Nordic Conference in Development Economics, Växjö 2026
QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop for PhD and Post-doctoral Students, London 2026
Doctorissimes, Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne 2026

"Blossoming Towns"

EBRD and CEPR Research Symposium on Demographic Change, London 2025
Women's Employment and Empowerment in Low-Income Countries, Royal Holloway 2025
Gender-Responsive Social Protection and Employment Policies, IDOS, Bonn 2024

"Distributional and Climate Implications of Policy Responses to Energy Price Shocks"

LSE Environment Day, London 2023

*Scheduled

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE AND AFFILIATIONS

Affiliated Scholar Mar 2024 – present
Data, Policy and Innovation Centre (DPIC) *Odisha, India*
A partnership between the Government of Odisha and the University of Chicago Trust.

Research Assistant to Professors Oriana Bandiera and Robin Burgess 2019 – 2021
London School of Economics and Political Science *London, UK*

TEACHING

Graduate Teaching Assistant

Topics in Development Economics (EC310), *University of Warwick* 2025–26
Microeconomic Principles I (EC201), *London School of Economics* 2020–21
Economics B (EC102), *London School of Economics* 2019–20

GRANTS

G2LM|LIC/STEG, "Women's Work in Markets of the 21st Century", £25,000, Co-PI 2025
STEG Small Research Grant, £15,000, Sole PI 2024
ESRC Overseas Fieldwork Grant, Midlands Graduate School DTP, £4,672 2024

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

ESRC Midlands Graduate School DTP Scholarship, 3.5-year award 2023–2027
Janet Beveridge Award for Outstanding Achievement, London School of Economics 2019

RESEARCH SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Software R (including GIS), Stata, LaTeX
Survey tools SurveyCTO, KoboToolbox
Languages English (native), French (fluent)

REFERENCES

Professor Anant Sudarshan
Department of Economics
University of Warwick
anant.sudarshan@warwick.ac.uk

Professor Stefano Caria
Department of Economics
University of Oxford
stefano.caria@economics.ox.ac.uk

Professor Sharun Mukand
Department of Economics
University of Warwick
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ABSTRACTS

"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns" **(Job Market Paper)**

Bonded workers voluntarily trade their future labour for credit from their employer. The price of this credit is rarely made explicit, and has never been measured empirically. This paper quantifies it for India's 15 million brick kiln workers, and asks whether workers knowingly pay it. Partnering with employers, I advertise real vacancies with randomised terms to 1,494 Odisha households. Workers favour jobs offering lower pay but larger advances by 10 percentage points, implicitly borrowing at over 19.5% per month. This partly reflects credit market failures: applications concentrate amongst credit constrained workers and spike after negative income shocks. However, workers underestimate what advances cost, and three quarters wrongly believe high advance jobs pay more. Telling workers the true pay gap does not change beliefs. Among those who most need cash, it even raises demand for high advance jobs. Regulating against these contracts would therefore protect some workers from costly mistakes, but deny others a lifeline.

"Blossoming Towns", with Niclas Moneke and Céline Zipfel

Towns and cities create jobs and income. Can the arrival of new jobs also create a town? We study large agro-industrial labour demand shocks in rural sub-Saharan Africa: flower farms in Kenya. Rising production costs in Europe generate a boom in Kenyan cut-flower export production, providing stable wage jobs for mostly low-skilled women. We exploit the specific requirements of cut-flower production to track the arrival and growth of greenhouses over the last two decades. We find large increases in wage employment and home-to-market transformation within agriculture, especially for women. Urbanisation unfolds: population growth and in-migration are flanked by an emerging private rental market for housing. Housing quality and infrastructure access improve, wealth accumulates. Educational investments increase while fertility decreases. Suggestive evidence highlights that the resulting towns initiate occupational change, motivate forward-looking investment and even survive flower farm closures – indicating towns that can sustain themselves as centres of economic activity.

"Jobs to End Poverty: Evidence from Bangladesh", with Oriana Bandiera, Robin Burgess, Stefano Caria, Munshi Sulaiman and Jack Thiemel

Do the poor have high returns from trainable human capital? Can they afford to pay for it? And are they differentially targeted by the organizations that offer training? We provide unique evidence on these questions by combining a household census (N=42,895) in urban Bangladesh, a randomized controlled trial of an on-the-job training intervention, unique data on the targeting of the implementing partner, and a structural model. We find that take-up of the training at full price is minimal, and there are no effects on labor market outcomes. The poor, however, increase employment and consumption under a 70% discount. We also document that, for the same program, the implementing NGO would have selected richer beneficiaries who are more likely to enroll in training. Our structural model rationalizes these findings by estimating that the poor have higher-than-average returns to training, but they also experience higher participation costs, and are hence targeted less frequently by an implementer that wants to maximise take-up. We confirm the central finding that the poor have higher-than-average returns to training in a re-analysis of previous training experiments, using machine learning predictions of outcomes and treatment effects.